



Agent 001

agent001@thinkdigit.com

The death of my earphones, a sad day in my life, but a good one as well. Time for a change, an upgrade to something better, bigger, clearer and louder. It was high time I got myself a good pair of headphones in a decent budget. As I spend a lot of time travelling, I wanted something that was portable to some extent, but also fully capable of taking advantage of a headphone amp or my PC's sound card if the need arose. Time to hit the streets (or the internet, as the case may be).

Straightaway the headphones that come to mind are the Sennheiser PX100, KOSS PortaPro and the Grado Sr60i. All of the above headphones are designed to be portable and can be folded up in some form or the other, the PX 100 being the most compact of them all. The KOSS headphone in particular bears special mention. Retailing for about ₹4,000, the Porta Pro is a very old design, but has been well received by the public, plus, it comes with a no-questions-asked lifetime warranty. A very good deal for the butter fingered amongst us. The PX100 comes in 2 variants – the older PX 100 I and the current PX100 II. The PX100 II retails for about ₹2,800 and is a very good buy, especially compared to the Porta Pro. The audio quality is quite similar with very little noticeable difference under

Your personal slice of audio nirvana

With the plethora of headphones available in the market, we help you pick the ideal headphone most suited to your needs

normal use. Ditto the PX100 I, which, if you can hunt around for, can make for a killer deal at around ₹1,800. Unfortunately, it's no more in production and will

you can happily connect it to your TV and enjoy the sound from the comfort of your couch. If you can't find the PX100 I, the sound quality of the Sennheiser PX80 is quite close to that of the PX100s and it's

definitely worth it at the price.

One important thing to note about all the headphones mentioned above is that they all have impedance ranging from 16 ohms to 38 ohms. This is important as higher impedance headphones will be difficult to drive using just a PMP or your onboard sound card and you'll lose out on volume and depth as well.

Since I own a portable amp (E5) and have a dedicated sound card (Xonar Essence), I wanted something a little more powerful. After much scrounging around, I finally spotted the Sennheiser HD595 and Audio Technica A900. Both are brilliant headphones and have received some excellent reviews so it was a very tough decision to

make. Specification-wise, both are quite similar, the major difference being in the price, ₹11,500 for the 595 and about ₹14,000 for the A900. Finally, I settled on the Sennheiser HD 595, mainly since most audiophile reviewers claimed that the difference was not much, *and* the fact that the A900, at ₹14,000 are just too expensive. A relative in the right place can get them for you at barely \$200 (₹10,000). If I didn't have an amp or sound card, I would have settled for the Grado Sr60i without any hesitation. If only the A900s had been cheaper though...



take some effort to find. This brings me to the Grado Sr60i. I've never actually tried these headphones and was sorely tempted to place an order for it based on the very positive reviews it received. Only available online and in a few select stores, it retails for approximately ₹5,000.

For the budget conscious, I spotted a pair of Sennheiser HD202s for ₹1,300. A very decent set of headphones, it can easily match Sony and Philips headphones worth much more. It also comes bundled with an extremely long cable so